

Build an attack that can arrive

An attack needs access, coordination, and enough time. A threat that cannot survive the opponent's best defense is only a hope.

Identify a reason to attack. An exposed king, a lead in development, missing defenders, or open lines can justify direct action. If the opponent is well organized, improving your position may achieve more than a premature sacrifice.

Count relevant pieces. Ask how many attackers can actually reach the king and how many defenders can respond. A piece on the other side of the board may need several moves to matter.

Open a route. Use files, diagonals, or a pawn break to let pieces reach the target. Opening a line is helpful only if you can use it before the opponent does.

Remove the right defender. Exchanging a key knight or bishop may weaken a mating square. But calculate the recapture: another piece may take over the same job or the exchange may help the king escape.

Bring the next piece. If a queen and bishop cannot break through, look for a rook or knight that can join with a threat. Do not keep checking just because the checks are available.

Calculate a sacrifice completely enough. Look for acceptance, refusal, king escapes, interpositions, and queen trades. Know what you receive: a forced mate, recovered material, or enduring activity. If the compensation is unclear, compare a sound improving move.

A THREE-PART ATTACK PLAN

Name the entry square, the defender to displace, and the piece that will deliver the next threat. Then ask how the opponent can challenge each part.

When the attack ends

If queens come off, the king escapes, or the defender returns material, reassess. The right continuation may be a favorable endgame rather than another attacking move.

Defend the threat that exists

Accurate defense begins by separating a real threat from a move that only looks aggressive.

Name the threat precisely. State the move the opponent intends and why it works. If you cannot find a concrete threat, you may have time to improve your position or create counterplay.

List different kinds of defense. Move the target, defend it, block the line, capture the attacker, exchange a key piece, or create a stronger threat. Compare these options instead of automatically retreating.

Give the king a safe route. An escape square can prevent a back-rank mate, but a pawn push may weaken other squares. Confirm the square will actually be safe from enemy pieces.

Simplify for a reason. A queen trade often reduces mating danger. Make sure the trade is available and the resulting endgame is acceptable before pursuing it.

Return material when it solves the problem. Giving back an extra pawn or piece can remove a dangerous attacker and stabilize a winning position. Protect the result of the game rather than every point of material.

Look for active resistance. Checks, central breaks, and threats against the opponent's king may force them to slow down. Counterplay works only if you still survive the immediate threat.

WHEN IN CHECK

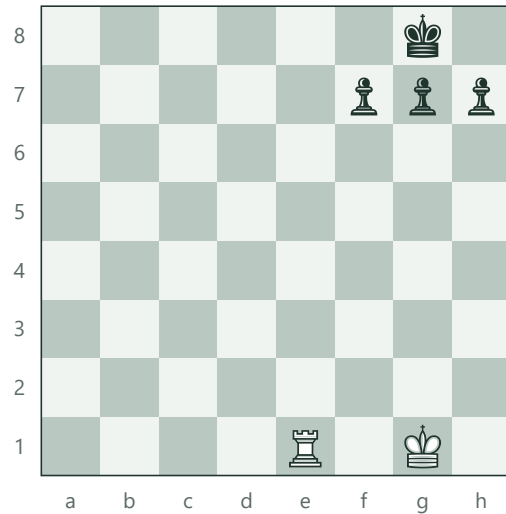
For a single check, look for a legal king move, capture of the checking piece, or interposition against a line check. Knight checks cannot be blocked. In double check, the king must move.

Reset after a mistake

Count the new material balance and find the opponent's immediate threat. Spend the next move solving the current position. An emotional attempt to recover everything at once often creates a second mistake.

Recognize the final mating picture

Solve each position before reading its answer. Check every escape square and every possible capture of the checking piece.



A. White to move. Find mate in one.

Clue

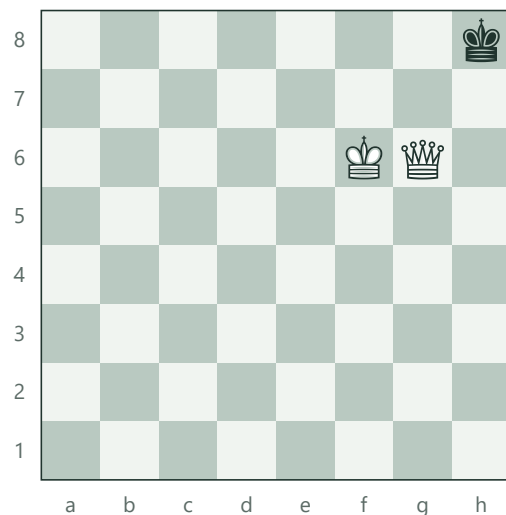
Black's pawns occupy the king's escape squares on the seventh rank.

Answer: 1.Re8#

The rook checks along the eighth rank. The king cannot escape to f8 or h8, and its own pawns block f7, g7, and h7.

Defensive lesson

Recognize a vulnerable back rank before the final check. An escape square or an active defender may be needed.



B. White to move. Find a supported queen mate.

Answer: 1.Qg7#

The queen checks the king on h8 and controls g8 and h7. White's king on f6 protects the queen on g7.

Check the turn

This is the same piece placement used for stalemate in Guide 04. Here White moves; with Black to move, the position is already drawn.

CONTINUE WITH INTERACTIVE CHECKMATE DRILLS

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